

Vanika Sok

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Education	Lafayette College Bachelor of Arts in Mathematics Bachelor of Arts in Economics	Easton, PA May 2026
	Honors in Economics Candidate Primary advisor: Professor David Stifel Second reader: Professor Susan L. Averett Third reader: Professor Daniel Turek	
Relevant Courses	Linear Algebra (Spring 2024), Probability (Fall 2024), Mathematical Statistics (Spring 2025), Abstract Algebra (Fall 2025), Advanced Regression Analysis (Fall 2025), Real Analysis (Planned to take in Spring 2026)	
Extracurricular	Orientation Leader and First-Year Mentor; Mentor for Lafayette Initiative for Malagasy Education (LIME) Lafayette Investment Club, International Student Association, Women in Computing, Women in Math	
Teaching Experience	Teaching Assistant, Lafayette College ECON 253: Econometrics; Professor Matthew Larsen ECON 251: Intermediate Microeconomics; Professor Sayorn Chin PHYS 131: Mechanics; Professor Paul Stonaha	Fall 2025 Fall 2024 Spring 2024
Honors and Awards	Omicron Delta Epsilon (ODE), the National Honor Society for Economics	2025
	Best Overall Hackathon Award Best overall hackathon award from Lafayette College's Association for Computer Machinery for a project on a mental health website featuring a chatbox, games, and videos designed to alleviate stress.	Feb. 2023
	SHE-CAN Scholar Selected for the SHE-CAN scholarship program based on excellence in academics, project management, leadership skills, and public speaking.	2020 – Present
Research Experience	University of Utah , Office of Undergraduate Research <i>Researcher, Dept. of Economics</i> Led quantitative research at the University of Utah by cleaning, merging, and analyzing 15+ years of large-scale panel data using Python, R, and Stata. Applied econometric techniques (OLS, fixed effects, instrumental variables) to study public library use and childcare affordability during economic downturns, and developed a strategic framework to guide resource allocation during recessions. Co-authored two research papers in progress, integrating evidence from the Great Recession and COVID-19 to generate actionable insights for policy and organizational decision-making.	Salt Lake City, UT May 2025 – Present
	Lafayette College , Dept. of Economics <i>Research Assistant</i> Applied a two-way fixed-effects research design to uncover a significant wage premium for occupations involving ethical tradeoffs, with effects increasing by age and education. Presented findings at Lafayette College's Poster Symposium, demonstrating how markets price moral considerations and offering insights with implications for workforce management, compensation strategies, and organizational decision-making.	Easton, PA May 2023 – May 2025
	Analyzed how crop diversification affects household welfare in Nigeria, leveraging World Bank panel survey data. Applied econometric models, data wrangling, and visualization in Excel and Stata to quantify the relationship between agricultural diversity and economic well-being. Produced insights on how diversification strategies can strengthen household resilience and inform development policy.	

Works in Progress

“Does woman empowerment improve household welfare?”

Abstract Women’s empowerment in developing countries remains understudied, particularly its impact on household welfare. This study examines how women’s land ownership and education, used as proxies intra-household bargaining power, affect household welfare indicators such as expenditures, human capital, and child health. Using Demographic and Health Surveys (DHS) data from Cambodia spanning 1998 to 2022, this study analyzes how these empowerment measures relate to household and child outcomes, particularly anthropometric indicators. The results contribute to the literature on gender and development by providing new evidence from Cambodia and may inform policies targeting household welfare, nutrition, and health.

“Further Evidence on Pollution, Crime, and Anti-Social Behavior” coauthored with Sayorn Chin and Salvador Lurbé (Lead Data Scientist at Mountain Data Group, Fort Collins, Colorado)

Abstract Recent literature has identified an association between short-term pollution exposure and crime in the US and in the United Kingdom (UK). In this paper, we expand our understanding of the effects of pollution on crime by looking at the association between pollution, specifically at Particulate Matter (PM) and Ozone (O₃), and counts of aggregated crime types and Anti-social Behaviour (ASB) in the UK. We primarily focus our analysis on ASB, as the literature has identified costs associated with them in the UK, but has overlooked its association with pollution. Using a fixed effects model, we found an association between pollution and some crime types, especially those that are economically motivated. We find weaker evidence of an association between pollution and offenses associated with aggressive and violent behavior (including ASB), and we discuss potential mechanisms in the context of the rational choice crime model. We conclude that one potential mechanism could be a decrease in the utility of the non-punishable alternative activity, or a decrease of the offender’s value of the future costs associated with being caught.

“Unemployment and Public Library Usage in the United States: Evidence from Before and During the COVID-19 Pandemic” coauthored with Sarah Small and Rachel Ernst (Department of Economics and J. Willard Marriott Library, University of Utah, Salt Lake City, Utah)

Abstract Scholars and policymakers have long argued that public libraries offer essential community resources during times of economic strife. However, to our knowledge, most of this evidence has been anecdotal or correlational. Using Public Library Survey, Bureau of Labor Statistics, and Business Dynamic Statistics datasets, we present causal estimates of the effect of regional unemployment on local public library usage. From OLS and instrumental variable models, we find that from 2008 to 2019, increased rates of unemployment led to increased visits, circulation, and computer usage at local libraries. However, during the COVID-19 pandemic, many of these relationships reversed, with COVID-related unemployment causing a reduction in visits, but not necessarily use. Reflecting on various dimensions of community need and library resources, we contextualize our results in the broader literature on public libraries as valuable economic resources.

“Do Public Libraries Fill Care Gaps? Regional Analyses of Children’s Library Programming, Childcare Markets, and Parenthood” coauthored with Sarah Small and Rachel Ernst

Abstract Public libraries are regularly relied upon for community resources beyond just books. In this paper, we ask: do public libraries help fill care gaps? Using data from the United States Public Library Surveys and the National Database on Childcare Prices, we construct a panel of public libraries from 2008 to 2022 matched with corresponding demographic and childcare pricing information in their respective counties. Using these data, we estimate how family demographics and care costs relate to attendance in children’s programming and circulation of children’s books in public libraries. Ultimately, we find that in counties with more single mothers, higher home-based childcare prices, and higher rates of family-level poverty, libraries have higher attendance in young children’s programming activities and greater children’s book circulation. We test the robustness of our results using several instrumental variable analyses and falsification tests. Ultimately, we suggest that libraries serve as important public spaces of social reproduction.

Research
Presentation

Poster Symposiums and Presentations

Presented research poster “Unemployment and Public Library Usage in the United States” at Lafayette College Symposium (Fall 2025) and Lafayette Bicentennial Celebration.

Presented research poster “The Compensation of Conscience” at Lafayette College Poster Symposium (Spring 2025).

Presented research poster “Unemployment and Public Library Usage in the United States” at University of Utah Undergraduate Research Symposium (Summer 2025).

Shared findings on childcare markets and public library programming at University of Utah Summer Research Symposium (2025).

Research
Assistant

“The Compensation of Conscience”, Sayorn Chin
This paper has been submitted to the *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*

Abstract Markets are often praised for their efficiency, but they can also incentivize individuals to act against their moral convictions. This study quantifies the “price of conscience” in labor markets, investigating whether jobs requiring moral compromise offer higher wages. Using data from the National Longitudinal Survey of Youth 1997 (NLSY97) and Occupational Information Network (O*NET), we conduct a longitudinal fixed-effects analysis to examine how conscience-related job characteristics influence wages. Our findings suggest that occupations demanding greater moral compromise provide higher wages, and this premium increases with age and education. These results extend prior experimental evidence on morals and markets into real-world labor market dynamics.

Skills

Programming
Python, R, MySQL, Java, HTML

Software
Git/GitHub, Stata, L^AT_EX

Languages
English (fluent), Khmer (native), Chinese (intermediate)

Conferences

International Confederation of Associations for Pluralism in Economics Philadelphia, PA
Scheduled to present papers at the annual conference in Philadelphia in January 2026

International Day of Women and Girls in Science, 11 February United Nations, NYC
Participated in UN sessions on gender equity in STEM; applied takeaways to LIME mentoring and Women in Computing outreach.

Grace Hopper Conference Orlando, FL
Represented Lafayette College’s Women in Computing club. I shared my experiences and engaged in discussions to learn from other women’s experiences in the technology and STEM fields.

SHE-CAN Leadership Summit 2024 San Francisco Bay Area
Annual, weekend long, in-person summit in the San Francisco Bay Area. Summit Theme: The Perpetual Power of One: How You Can Make a Difference. Summit Mission Statement: The “Perpetual Power of One” is the realization that individual actions and contributions, no matter how small they may seem at the outset, can create a ripple effect that continues over time and inspires others to make their own contributions.

Leadership Summit San Francisco Bay Area
Selected to attend the 2023 SHE-CAN Leadership Summit, an annual weekend-long event in the San Francisco Bay Area, focused on how leadership can drive sustainability, conscious capitalism, social justice, and the empowerment of women.

Leadership
and Volunteering

Lafayette Initiative for Malagasy Education (LIME) Madagascar
Math Tutor Dec. 2024 – Present
Selected for a 1.5-year commitment with the LIME; traveled to Antananarivo, Madagascar (Winter 2025)

to mentor high school students, providing academic guidance, leadership training, and support in preparing for competitive university and scholarship applications to the U.S.

Cambodian Student Association in the United States

Washington, DC

Director of Finance

Sep. 2023 – May 2025

Managed all financial operations, securing grants from the Cambodian Embassy and extending the student budget by 125 percent. Oversaw fund allocation across departments to maximize ROI, maintained full financial records, and collaborated with the Board of Directors to authorize and disburse funds in compliance with CASUSA's constitution, supporting the association's mission to build a welcoming community for Cambodian students in the U.S.

SHE-CAN Make A Change Project: Higher Education Fair

Siem Reap, Cambodia

Founder

Mar. - Jun. 2024

Brought the first-ever Higher Education Fair to live at a Rural High School in Siem Reap province. Drawn over 300 students participation from 12 different high school across Cambodia and invited four incredible speakers. All this made possible due to the help of my younger sister, and a team of six brilliant volunteers whom we recruited from 200+ student who filled out our volunteer application form.

Center of Khmer Studies and American Corner

Siem Reap, Cambodia

1st and 2nd Book Fair Team Leader and Speaker

Apr.- Jul. 2022 and May-Jun. 2023

Planned and executed 3-month project to organize inaugural book fair in Siem Reap. Sent invitations to 20 high schools, universities, and other educational institutions, driving 5,000 in-person attendees. Collaborated with 25 publishers, libraries, bookstores, universities, and educational institutions to display their products, securing donations, increasing event attendance 525 percent over projections. Supervised Booth and Registration teams and emceed 5000 person event. After the great success of the first book fair, our team returned in 2023 with more major exhibitors from across the country.

United States Agency for International Development

Siem Reap, Cambodia

Student Representative

November 2021

Led group discussions on career development and education challenges in rural areas Cambodia, delivering public speeches and fostering group discussions on 5-year plans to develop Cambodia.

Cambodia Women's Crisis Center

Siem Reap, Cambodia

Community Service Volunteer

Aug.-Oct. 2021

Organized events for 35 families in my community to raise awareness of domestic violence and sex trafficking. Organized events with the center to raise awareness and educate community and incoming tourists. Directed underprivileged households to the hotlines number to reduce impact of domestic assault across Cambodia.

References

David Stifel (Advisor)

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Department Head

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University of Utah

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